Chess Tournament Packing List

Tick it off the night before: for the player, and for the grown-up who drives, waits and cheers.



Tournament: _____ Date: _____ Player: _____

Essential gear

- [ ] Chess clock, with fresh batteries
- [ ] Tournament-legal chess set and board
- [ ] Score sheets or a scorebook
- [ ] Two notation pens
- [ ] Membership card or number (US Chess, ECF or your federation)
- [ ] Entry confirmation and the round times
- [ ] Glasses, if worn
- [ ]

Comfort and focus

- [ ] Water bottle
- [ ] Quiet snacks (no crinkly packets)
- [ ] Layers: tournament halls are unpredictable
- [ ] Silent fidget toy or stress ball
- [ ] A book or puzzles for between rounds
- [ ] Tissues
- [ ]

Parent survival kit

- [ ] Phone charger and headphones
- [ ] A book of your own
- [ ] Cash for entry fees and the café
- [ ] Packed lunch: venue food is often dire
- [ ] Directions and parking information
- [ ] A folding chair, if the hall has none
- [ ]

Tournament details

Venue and address _____

Organiser or control desk phone _____

Round 1	Round 2	Round 3	Round 4	Round 5	Round 6	Round 7

Check before you go: many tournaments provide sets and clocks on every board, and some ask players to bring their own. The entry information says which.

The morning-of timeline

The night before	Pack this list. Test the clock. Lay out clothes. An early night beats extra study.
2 hours before round 1	A slow breakfast (porridge, toast, eggs). Nothing new or heavy on tournament day.
1 hour before	Leave, with time for parking and a wrong turn.
30 to 45 minutes before	Arrive. Check in at the control desk, find the pairings, take a photo of the round times.
15 minutes before	Toilet, water, find the board. Write both names on the score sheet.
5 minutes before	Phones off and in the bag, not in a pocket. Under FIDE's Laws of Chess a phone on a player can lose the game; junior events set their own rules.
Between rounds	Eat, drink, walk around. Ask what they enjoyed, not what went wrong.

Forgot it? The emergency plan

Forgot the clock or set?
Ask at the control desk: organisers often keep spares, and families nearby usually share between rounds.

Forgot a pen or score sheets?
The control desk nearly always has both.

Forgot food?
Find the café or the nearest shop before round 1, not in a rush between rounds.

Forgot the membership number?
Organisers can usually look it up. Save it in your phone's notes for next time.

Forgot the round time?
Check the pairings wall or the tournament page. That photo from check-in helps.

Forgot their nerve?
Nerves are normal. A short walk, a drink of water and one deep breath before the handshake.

Round by round

Round	Colour	Result	One thing that went well
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			

Puzzles for between rounds: the free 50-puzzle pack at stillwareltd.com/tools/chess-vision-offline-puzzles/, or RankUp Chess, our chess academy for kids, which works with no internet.